

Organise Your Photos with digiKam

digiKam is a simple, well-designed photo management tool, which allows us to import and organise digital photos easily. It is an open source image organiser and tag editor written in C++, and is very easy to use.

If you do not have digiKam installed, you can download it for Linux or Windows from the digiKam download page. It may happen that your OS doesn't have the latest version, but there's nothing to worry about, as digiKam is a complete and stable application. So unless you're looking for an exact feature that only exists in the latest version, an earlier version is fine, especially if you are just a beginner.

After downloading, when you first launch digiKam, you will get a brief setup wizard (see Figure 1).

Read the screen carefully to decide what you really want because this can affect the performance and file size. But don't worry, as all the settings can be changed later. So, if you are not sure, it's better to accept all the default settings.

The preliminary launch of digiKam will be slow because it will analyse the photographs in your album and record information of each one. The time taken will totally depend on the number of photo albums in your system. It may run overnight too, if the album is large.

Interface

The design of digiKam is quite simple, particularly if you are a KDE customer. The fundamentals are easy to understand — on the left are panels that manage how you view photos, in the middle are the photos, and effects and filters are on the right.

The default view of digiKam is a file system view that shows the directory, which you have defined as your picture folder while installing it. digiKam refers to whatever directories it finds in your



Figure 1: Configuration

defined picture directory as an *album*. It parses each image file with its native metadata, as well as with the metadata digiKam allows you to add, into a thumbnail view.

After selecting the album, the photos within that album are displayed as an array in the right panel. There are also a lot of other ways to view your photos; they are all accessible as vertical tabs. Apart from the view, there are other features as well, as listed below.

Tags: These filter your photos by arbitrary metadata tags. At the start, there won't be any tags, but you can create them in the *Tag Manager* interface and allocate them to pictures. After assigning the tags, when you click on one from the *Tag panel* filter, it shows the photos that are assigned.

Labels: These filter your pictures according to how many stars you've given to a photograph. There are other types of labels too, such as colour labels and flags — all user-assignable from the thumbnail view.

Dates, timeline and map: This feature lets you view pictures by pertinent data contained in the photo's EXIF (exchangeable image file format) information.

Facial recognition: This feature acknowledges faces, and can even guess their identity. Initially, scanning your whole collection of photos from the beginning will take a while, but once it is done, digiKam will quickly analyse a new photo when it is added. So, at the start, have some patience while using digiKam.

